public meetings, she lashed out. ‘What were parties like the Jan Sangh doing when the country was under foreign rule?’ she asked with an oratorical flourish. *Organiser* gleefully pounced back, saying, ‘Even we didn’t expect her to know that the Jan Sangh came into being *after* the British were gone.’[7]

The Jan Sangh, closely intertwined with the RSS, never came close to challenging the Congress’s electoral dominance, even though it had become large enough to feature as one of the primary poles of ideological opposition in some poll contests. The Jan Sangh’s alternative idea of India as a country deeply rooted in Hindu ideals, as opposed to Nehru’s idea of a republic rooted in a distinction between the state and religious identity, did not win enough political traction. Ultimately, the Jan Sangh was forced to merge into a common Opposition front in 1977 and then reincarnate itself as the BJP in 1980. It is striking, all the same, just how much of its intellectual foundations from the 1950s are woven into the fabric of the modern BJP in the 2020s.

Why Hindu Nationalists Hated Nehru: The Jan Sangh’s Founding Moment

Virtually from the moment of its birth, the Akhil Bharatiya Jan Sangh cast itself as the cultural and political opposite of the Congress. When its founding delegates met in Delhi to create a new national party on 21 October 1951, the meeting opened with the ‘singing of the Vande Mataram and the chanting of Vedic mantras’.[8] On the stage sat the party’s founder, Syama Prasad Mookerjee, with other party leaders. They were framed by a white backdrop, displaying pictures of the seventeenth-century Maratha king Shivaji and the sixteenth-century Rajput warrior Maharana Pratap: both Hindu chieftains who became emblems of Hindu nationalism because they had battled Muslim emperors.[9]

State-level units had already been formed in some provinces (Bengal, Punjab–PEPSU, i.e. Patiala and East Punjab States Union, Himachal Pradesh, UP). Now, 500 delegates from across India converged on Delhi to merge into a national outfit.[10] They were